

PERCUSSION-CAP PISTOLS

The **percussion cap** (see pp.80–81) was simply a small cup containing primer, yet it enabled a revolution in the design of all handheld firearms. While flintlock pistols were bulky, the percussion cap made it possible to design sleeker and more compact handguns with fewer lock components. It made muzzle-loading pistols more reliable, and eventually spurred the development of more efficient breech-loading pistols. Among pistols, the revolver—with its chambers in a revolving cylinder—improved most significantly with the coming of percussion-cap technology.



▲ FRENCH TARGET PISTOL

Date 1839
Origin France
Barrel 11¼in (28.3cm)
Caliber .47in (12mm)

Technically, there is little difference between dueling pistols and those used for shooting at paper targets. However, the latter, such as this example by the renowned Parisian gunmaker Gastinne-Renette, were often beautifully decorated.

▲ PATTERN 1842 COASTGUARD PISTOL

Date 1842
Origin UK
Barrel 6in (15cm)
Caliber .57in (14.7mm)

British pistols used by the coastguard, police, and other security agencies were similar in style to the Land- and Sea-Pattern pistols of the army and navy, but usually lighter and smaller. In this muzzle-loading pistol, the ramrod retainer swiveled to allow the captive rod to be inserted in the barrel. Revolvers replaced Pattern 1842 pistols in the 1850s.

▲ BAR-HAMMER PEPPERBOX PISTOL

Date 1849
Origin UK
Barrel 3½in (9.1cm)
Caliber .55in (13.9mm)

Pepperbox pistols had multiple barrels, which offered the advantage of multishot cylinder revolvers without their principal drawback—the leakage of propellant gas between chamber and barrel. Unfortunately, these pistols were generally inaccurate, except at point-blank range.